

8, The Halting of The Great Expansion Carries Equal Historical Significance to Its Inception

The Great Expansion and its monumental significance are effortless to observe. After all, the frontiers of civilization expanded staggeringly over the span of several centuries—a phenomenon undeniably impossible for any observer to overlook, let alone the fact that its late stages forged several immortal empires.

However, a highly crucial point that frequently eludes people's attention is this: **The halting of the expansion possesses a historical significance equally profound as the expansion itself!** The attainment of definitive, fixed borders by classical empires was a paramount driving force for **feudalization**.

Why must we assert this?

First, we can conduct a simple thought experiment. When human society transitions from a **slavery society** (which directly exploits labor) to a **feudal society** (which exploits agricultural surplus via rent and taxation), the fundamental essence of this transition—regardless of how it specifically evolved, and though impossible to quantify perfectly—is that **land supplanted labor to occupy the primary position among factors of production** (首位生产要素)!

Obviously, the most decisive factor triggering this mutation was the elevation of productive forces, making the **feudal mode of production** more efficient and yielding superior economic benefits for the ruling class. However, one must not forget that beyond this decisive factor, other variables exist. Among them, one conceptually paramount factor warrants specific attention: **"Scarcity"** (稀缺性).

This is exactly like the glaringly obvious principles of economics: when the quantity of anything multiplies to a certain magnitude, its "scarcity" drops below a certain threshold, and its perceived importance inevitably plummets. Because no one lacks it, no one considers it vital. Conversely, if an entity is indispensable to the production process, the scarcer it is, the more immense value people will attach to it!

Land is precisely such an entity. From the simplest logical deduction, it is not difficult to comprehend: If land is perpetually abundant relative to the population, the importance of land will be suppressed. Under such circumstances, rulers will inevitably attempt to intensify their absolute control over the physical bodies and the dependency relationships of the ruled, stripping away even more of their rights. **Population—rather than land—is thus elevated to the most paramount position!**

This scenario is phenomenally detrimental to the formation of a **feudal order**, because excessive elements of a slavery society are retained.

A slightly more recent historical example might elucidate this point: the "Great Divergence" (分流) between Western and Eastern Europe beginning in the 15th century. The traditional interpretation posits that as Western Europe's commercial and industrial economy developed and marched toward a capitalist society, serfdom (农奴制) inversely expanded in Central and Eastern Europe.

We must point out that while this "Divergence" theory possesses merit, it severely neglects the intrinsic temporal disparities in developmental trajectories across different regions. Eastern Europe's **feudalization** originally commenced roughly five centuries later than Western Europe's, and it was subsequently devastated by the shockwaves of the Mongol conquests. Therefore, when Western Europe was shedding serfdom, the fact that Eastern Europe was simultaneously intensifying it is

inherently unremarkable! However, the tightening of pan-European market connections indeed exacerbated this trend. The industrializing cities of Western Europe generated a massive demand for imported grain, which naturally stimulated Eastern European **feudal lords** to tighten their grip on agricultural production, thereby reinforcing serfdom (*often termed the "Second Serfdom"*).

The core issue lies here: this theory seemingly cannot explain *every* Eastern European nation, particularly Russia.

The Russians and the Poles acquired maritime outlets almost simultaneously in the late 15th century, yet they adopted diametrically opposed policies. After conquering Gdańsk (格但斯克 / known to the Germans as Danzig), the Poles inherited the Hanseatic League's trade network there, aggressively utilizing it as the Kingdom of Poland's premier commercial port for foreign trade. Conversely, after the Grand Duchy of Moscow conquered Novgorod (诺夫哥罗德), the measure it adopted was to outright expel the Hanseatic merchants! For the ensuing three centuries, the volume of agricultural products exported by Russia remained vanishingly minuscule, a reality unchanged even by the establishment of the English Muscovy Company (英国-莫斯科公司).

Yet, despite this isolation from the Western export market, **the intensification of Russian serfdom was the most draconian among all Eastern European nations!** The legal status of serfs was explicitly codified: they were deemed the absolute property of the landlord, possessed virtually zero personal freedom, faced severe restrictions on migration, were subjected to forced labor on manorial estates, and lacked any economic autonomy. **This condition became fundamentally indistinguishable from outright slavery!**

Why did such a terrifying trend emerge? I contend that the harsh physical reality of Eastern Europe—**vast territories paired with a sparse population** (地广人稀)—was a paramount catalyst. Confronted with a catastrophic shortage of labor, it is entirely unsurprising that Russian rulers desired to maximize their control over the bodies of the laboring underclass.

Let alone a nation like Russia, where the **feudal system** was insufficiently developed! Even in the labor-starved New World—within newly independent regimes that had completely inherited the legacy of Western European **feudal societies**—some nations failed to abolish slavery for an exceedingly long time, such as Brazil. Even in the United States, which was already a "bourgeois democratic regime" (资产阶级民主政权 / *I use the phrasing customary in China here, hoping it does not confuse readers*) at the time of its independence, slavery in the South was only eradicated nearly a century after the nation's founding!

16th-century Russian society was vastly more backward: **feudal** contractual relations were underdeveloped, urbanization was severely retarded, the burgher class (市民阶层) was impotent, the economy was sealed off, and the monumental ideological revolutions spawned by medieval society were utterly invisible in Russia. Under these circumstances, one genuinely could not expect Russia to embark on any trajectory other than the extreme fortification of serfdom!

Starting from the 16th century, the Russians leveraged advanced Western military technology to execute military conquests toward the East and South that spanned over three centuries. Any observer would likely marvel at how effortlessly this process unfolded! A minuscule number of Russian conquerors advanced in a "zigzag" pattern along the massive rivers of Siberia, effortlessly repelling indigenous Tatars who outnumbered them tenfold merely by relying on primitive wooden bastions (木质棱堡), eventually reaching the Pacific Ocean! Shortly thereafter, the Tatars of

Southern Russia were subjugated, followed by the Caucasus region and Central Asia. (*The reason I do not consider the nations conquered to Russia's west, like Poland, in this context is because their population densities were not necessarily lower than Russia's heartland, and thus they do not factor into this specific dynamic*).

This astronomical territorial growth exacerbated the already dire scarcity of manpower. The constantly shifting frontiers made Russian rulers pathologically vigilant against serf flights, particularly terrified of anti-serfdom rebellions actively resisting the Russian central authority from these frontier regions. For intelligent and ruthless autocrats like Peter the Great (彼得一世) and Catherine the Great (叶卡捷琳娜二世), they fundamentally had no option but to further intensify the oppression of the serfs!

The demographic fluctuations in Russian history laterally corroborate this point. Between 1700 and 1900—even if we exclusively consider ethnic Russians to deliberately filter out the demographic impact of conquered regions—Tsarist Russia remained the fastest-growing nation globally in terms of population (*perhaps arguably without parallel*). (*This naturally excludes nations whose scales were too minuscule or immigrant nations that gained independence from European colonies*). If Russia hadn't repeatedly suffered catastrophic internal and external political disasters in the 20th century, this demographic explosion would have manifested even more phenomenally.

But then again, perhaps this very anomalous fortification of Russian serfdom—and the monumental setbacks it implied for Russia's transition from a **feudal society** to a capitalist society—was precisely the root cause of Russia's tragic and tumultuous destiny in the 20th century!

Regardless of whether in China or abroad, territorial expansion is universally lauded as the "glorious achievement" (盛事) of an empire. However, the history of the **feudal period** proves that annexing massive territories—especially vast, sparsely populated lands awaiting development—during an inappropriate social stage is highly likely to trigger a severe reactionary backlash against social progress!

This mirrors what people observe during the Age of Discovery: Spain and Portugal, obsessed with "carving up the world" and annexing colossal territories, rapidly plummeted into decay, while the Netherlands, which prioritized commercial interests, secured dominance. However, once the capitalist system has firmly consolidated itself within the mother country, massive territorial annexations will no longer inflict structural damage upon the metropole (*the worst that could happen is simply allowing the colonies to gain independence in various forms later on*); the mother country's international status remains top-tier globally, as was the case with Britain and France. The profound complexity of human society is clearly evident here!

Perhaps some might ask: *Was the serfdom society in China's Tibet similarly governed by this dynamic?*

Because of contemporary political realities, the historical issue of Tibet has become almost impossible to examine objectively. The various factions engaged in the debate basically just vomit emotional rhetoric from their entrenched stances, making it exceedingly difficult for people to access reliable historical data.

However, Tibetan serfdom undeniably differs from the Russian scenario. When we describe Russia as having "vast territories and sparse populations" (地广人稀), we mean that the labor force was catastrophically insufficient *relative* to the massive expanse of *developable* land—not merely that

an enormous area possessed an abysmal ecological carrying capacity! Although the Tibetan region encompasses a colossal area, its natural conditions are genuinely atrocious. If the population on the plateau could inherently only be sustained at a meager level, then the labor force relative to the demands of extensive agricultural production was not necessarily "scarce."

Compared to Western Europe, or even Russia during its serfdom era, where a serf could still carve out a meager existence provided they successfully fled, **fleeing as a serf under Tibet's natural conditions was frequently a pure death sentence!** A serf's flight only possessed a sliver of viability in the border regions, escaping entirely out of the Tibetan plateau—for instance, migrating southward to Nepal or India, as the natural environment there was phenomenally superior.

Therefore, although **feudalization** indeed commenced following the collapse of the Tibetan Empire (吐蕃帝国), the Tibetan region—severely constrained by its physical geography—seemingly evolved an anomalous model. It relied intensely on religion as its binding nexus, with monasteries functioning as mega-feudal lords and regional governance centers. *(In morphology, it somewhat resembled the early city-states of Mesopotamia, where the state was organized around the temple).* This diverges significantly from the Russian paradigm.

At the conclusion of this section, we must point out that introducing "scarcity" as a **sub-variable** (副变量) alongside the **primary variable** (主变量) of productive forces to determine the status of various factors of production unexpectedly provides an exceptionally excellent predictive model for observing the rise and fall of humanity's **early states!**

We shall cast our gaze upon the ancient civilization of Mesopotamia. This is undeniably a premier, immaculate specimen for modern scholars to observe the evolution of **early states**. The civilization here birthed exceedingly early, and the historical epoch of its **early state** stage was monumentally protracted. Simultaneously, the earliest writing systems emerged here, and its script was phenomenally developed. The voluminous textual and archaeological evidence unearthed thus far allows us, at the very least, to grasp the holistic social panorama of ancient Mesopotamia across its various epochs.

More critically, Mesopotamia's environment was absolutely not as statically stable as Egypt's! **And it is precisely within a dynamic, fluctuating record of samples that objective laws can truly be illuminated!**

The various regimes of ancient Mesopotamian civilization were undoubtedly situated within the **early state** stage. Unskilled labor consistently occupied the paramount position among factors of production; consequently, the primary mode of exploitation was compulsory forced labor.

However, the Mesopotamia basin—particularly its lower reaches—was severely ravaged by soil salinization (土地盐碱化). Soil salinization decimates the acreage of usable land and astronomically inflates the costs of land utilization. Thus, during certain epochs, a specific paradigm could materialize: the population size became overwhelmingly excessive relative to the land available for cultivation!

Because the scarcity of land skyrocketed while the scarcity of labor plummeted, the dominant, ruling status of labor among the factors of production began to waver. Readers will readily think of the famous Third Dynasty of Ur (乌尔第三王朝). For many years prior to the establishment of the Third Dynasty of Ur, soil salinization in the Sumerian region had been steadily increasing. Consequently, wheat was gradually supplanted by the more salt-tolerant barley. During the absolute

zenith of the Third Dynasty of Ur, the agricultural output per unit of land plummeted by roughly 50% compared to the Early Dynastic Period!

Simultaneously, during the late Akkadian Empire, a global climatic drought event triggered catastrophic social crises in the rain-fed agricultural zones of northern Mesopotamia, forcing massive populations to migrate southward into the Sumerian region. Therefore, we observe that during the reign of the Third Dynasty of Ur, land manifested a state of acute shortage due to skyrocketing reclamation costs and plummeting yields, while settlement densities indicated a remarkably high population. **A brutal social reality of "overpopulation and land scarcity" (人多地少) had formed.**

Consequently, we can explicitly note that the Third Dynasty of Ur exhibited certain "**classical**" characteristics. The most representative among them was a highly complex bureaucratic system, so intricate that it genuinely bears the suspicion of being a form of **administrative totalitarianism** (行政极权主义)!

Undoubtedly, during the reign of the Third Dynasty of Ur, the status of land as a factor of production surged rapidly. Hence, we witness a pseudo-feudal logic akin to "tenancy" (租佃). While the state owned the public fields, it simultaneously leased massive tracts of tenant fields to individuals—usually bureaucrats or powerful local elites—collecting a fixed percentage of the harvest. Concurrently, the state distributed ration fields (口粮田) to bureaucrats, military officers, and even high-ranking artisans as an alternative to paying them wages in kind. From a morphological perspective, those granted land by the state were nominally serving the royal court, but because they possessed the rights to manage the land and expropriate its surplus value, they exhibited the distinct facade of a landlord class!

The renowned Great King Shulgi (舒勒吉), while maintaining his colossal bureaucratic apparatus, also deployed machinations characteristic of a classical monarch. On one hand, he obliterated the autonomous space of local powerful clans through standardized weights and measures, a unified calendar, and administrative "software"; on the other hand, through patronage, appointments, and dismissals, he funneled the youth of local families into specialized Sumerian-language schools, enabling them to serve in public office.

However, we must explicitly point out: **The Third Dynasty of Ur merely possessed classical characteristics; it was obviously light-years away from a true classical state!**

Feudalism could fundamentally never sprout from the political structure of the Third Dynasty of Ur because its agriculture was intensely **involved** (内卷)—meaning astronomical amounts of human and material resources were invested, yet the marginal returns were appallingly low. Landlords needed to remain parasites attached to a bureaucratic system to survive. If land ownership were fragmented into small parcels, the entire region would be incapable of maintaining the massive public works engineering required to ensure agricultural production.

In stark contrast, the genuine unfolding of **feudalization** is an irreversible revolution triggered by the sufficient development of productive forces! It makes land reclamation viable at the micro-unit level, even down to individual families. This is the very bedrock for the emergence of the **natural economy** during early **feudalization**. **Feudalization** is absolutely inseparable from the advent of advanced tools and technologies; they are what guarantee that land will surpass raw labor to occupy the paramount position among factors of production!

One can easily discern that although the Third Dynasty of Ur appeared to resemble a classical state regarding its highly developed bureaucratic system, it still conspicuously lacked myriad core features possessed by genuine classical states. In its essence, a **classical empire** is the product of productive forces developing to a highly specific stage. The empire can expropriate colossal surpluses through its bureaucratic system, and this surplus manifests in opulent urban civic life, a highly developed commodity economy, open-minded cultural creation, and ferocious outward expansion.

Conversely, the Third Dynasty of Ur was situated in the twilight phase of Sumerian civilization. The establishment of its system originated, to a large extent, from the social realities of severe ecological degradation and hyper-acute population-to-land contradictions; it was subsequently utilized to combat these detrimental factors. Therefore, the production surplus that the Third Dynasty of Ur could actually exploit was phenomenally limited! **Merely sustaining its own existence was an agonizing struggle!**

Thus, we observe that the territory of the Third Dynasty of Ur was vastly smaller than that of the Akkadian Empire; its core zone essentially retreated entirely into the alluvial plains of southern Mesopotamia. It was an introverted, high-pressure state. Judging from the limited historical records, the primary objective of its military operations was consolidating borders and maintaining domestic stability, even under the reign of a renowned monarch like Shulgi. Later, to fend off Amorite incursions, it even constructed the famous Amorite Wall (阿摩利墙) north of modern-day Baghdad. *(Naturally, when order collapsed from within, border fortifications were inevitably rendered useless).*

The Third Dynasty of Ur undoubtedly possessed magnificent cities, but the economic significance of these cities lay entirely in operating a rationing system (配给制). Under such circumstances, one fundamentally could not expect an independent burgher class (市民阶层) or cultural activities tailored to their aesthetics!

As for the literature of the Third Dynasty of Ur, it is even more notorious: heavily saturated with hymns to the royal court and the deification of the monarch, utterly devoid of the exploration of the unknown and the universal rationalism characteristic of classical imperial literary creation. Of course, we must point out that the literary forms of the Third Dynasty of Ur cannot be entirely blamed on the monarch's megalomania. Under such an extreme bureaucratic system, monarchs like Shulgi deifying themselves indeed served the pragmatic function of lowering the "verification costs" (校验成本) of a hyper-complex system. But this identically reflects the agonizing arduousness with which the Third Dynasty of Ur operated its convoluted bureaucracy.

Finally, we must point out that although the Third Dynasty of Ur appeared to process a colossal volume of imported and exported goods, it possessed virtually zero substantive "commodity economy" (商品经济)! It was merely operating a "quantified state logistics system" (国家物流量化系统) on an international scale. The primary objective of this state trading behavior was not to generate profit, but to ensure the state apparatus could acquire sufficient resources it could not produce domestically (*such as metal and timber*). And although silver was utilized as a standard of value (价值尺度) during this era, it was absolutely not an actual medium of exchange. Ordinary laborers and low-ranking bureaucrats were almost exclusively paid in physical rations!

Of course, we should not purely disparage the Third Dynasty of Ur; it is justifiably regarded as the "Sumerian Renaissance." The standardized writing system, weights and measures, and legal formats it pioneered paved the way for subsequent Near Eastern civilizations. This amply demonstrates that the immense concentration of resources and power under the rule of the Third Dynasty of Ur—beyond merely sustaining the operation of the system itself—also yielded magnificent civilizational outputs.

Ultimately, the institutional structure of the Third Dynasty of Ur can be perceived as a vast social experiment conducted amidst severe crises. It was *not* a scenario where rulers premeditatedly and systematically suffocated the entire society's future purely for short-term, selfish interests. However, the governance model of the Third Dynasty of Ur was inevitably doomed to be unsustainable. Bureaucratic systems possess an inherent proclivity for self-proliferation; overly microscopic and precise social management lacks the redundancy required to withstand sudden catastrophic shocks; and under labor-intensive agriculture, soil salinization would inevitably and inexorably worsen. Therefore, that the Third Dynasty of Ur managed to sustain its dynastic lifespan for an entire century is actually quite reasonable.

In stark contrast to the Third Dynasty of Ur, the later Kassite Dynasty (加喜特王朝) during the Middle Babylonian period confronted a diametrically opposed scenario: **"vast land and sparse population"** (地多人少). This was because, following the collapse of the Old Babylonian Empire, Mesopotamia was battered by prolonged warfare and plagues, resulting in a catastrophic loss of population. Relative to the surviving population, "distributable land" was in extreme surplus.

Consequently, the ruling logic of the Kassite Dynasty reverted squarely back to the **"physical human possession"** (人身占有) universally prevalent in **early states**. Rulers no longer pursued what percentage of grain the ruled could surrender; instead, they demanded that the subjects physically engage in corvée labor (徭役) at specific times. Within the *Kudurru* (库杜如 / boundary stones) steles of the Kassite Dynasty, there are voluminous records of kings bestowing massive tracts of land upon royal family members or high-ranking generals. Yet, the core privilege these steles emphasized was *not* the size or boundaries of the land, but rather **"the privilege of exempting the population on said land from performing corvée labor for the state"**!

These historical realities explicitly demonstrate that during the Kassite Dynasty, **labor was unquestionably the primary factor of production!** This aligns perfectly with humanity's understanding of a standard **early state**. In fact, the Kassite Dynasty is universally recognized as a regime in ancient Mesopotamia with a relatively low degree of bureaucratization and highly decentralized rule. The king essentially outsourced the jurisdiction over labor to his vassals—a practice remarkably reminiscent of the Western Zhou Dynasty's *Fengjian* system of "bestowing people and bestowing territories" (授民授疆土).

By examining two highly representative regimes within ancient Mesopotamian civilization, we have once again proven the absolute universality of our newly established sociological framework across human historical time and space!

Thus, we have executed a phenomenally effective, structural repair of Marx's "Historical Materialism" based on class analysis: **The mutations within the ruling class and corresponding class relations are dictated by shifts in the primary factor of production; and which factor of**

production commands dominance in a specific historical epoch is fundamentally determined by the developmental level of the productive forces!

Overall, up to the present day, unskilled labor, land, and capital have sequentially occupied the throne of the primary factor of production. This aligns perfectly with historical intuition:

1. In the agonizingly protracted epoch preceding the Agricultural Revolution, a minuscule number of humans lived across boundless expanses of land via hunting and gathering; naturally, **labor** was the most vital.
2. Following the conclusion of **The Great Expansion** around the dawn of the Common Era, the rise of **classical empires** expanded the influence of agricultural civilization across the vast majority of continents; thus, the **land** that sustained agriculture became the most vital.
3. After the Industrial Revolution, humanity transitioned from agricultural to industrial civilization, and the supremacy of **capital** became glaringly manifest.

Between these three archetypal states lie protracted transitional epochs. As **productive forces** continually advance, the relative importance of these factors of production is concurrently disrupted by **sub-variables** (副变量).

Among these latent sub-variables, the most prominent is "**Scarcity**" (稀缺性). The status of a surplus factor of production inevitably plummets, while the status of a deficient factor skyrockets. "**Scarcity**" **does not directly alter the productive forces, but it can monumentally mutate the relations of production!**

Another immensely influential factor is **Commercial Trade** (商业贸易). Trade alters neither the most fundamental productive forces nor the relations of production; instead, it acts directly upon the **superstructure** (上层建筑): **it can spectacularly artificially amplify the power of the state bureaucracy!** In antiquity, this manifested as nations situated along crucial trade routes exhibiting classical characteristics phenomenally early, or miraculously sustaining classical characteristics long after the classical era had ended. In the modern era, this manifests as certain major resource-exporting nations maintaining military power and geopolitical influence utterly disproportionate to their actual developmental levels.

By utilizing these three hierarchical influencing factors of varying significance, the entirety of human history can be fundamentally and coherently explained through this reconstructed theory of class evolution!

Finally, I shall briefly mention this: scarcity relations absolutely do not exclusively emerge between labor and land. Land and capital, and even labor and capital, identically constitute scarcity dynamics.

We must emphatically point out that—contrary to what those benevolent and naive Western observers perceive—the staggering "scarcities" that materialize within **restoration-bureaucratic states** are absolutely not "operational failures of the system." Rather, they are highly likely "**necessary mechanisms deliberately engineered for the express purpose of maintaining the regime's own existence!**"

Unlike commercial speculators who hoard commodities merely to turn a quick, short-term profit, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** deliberately attempts—across generations, or even vastly

longer timeframes—to **artificially manufacture scarcity**! Its goal is to coercively distort and reverse the relations of production purely to preserve its despotic rule! **This caliber of diabolical, Machiavellian malice is something absolutely incomprehensible to anyone who has not lived within it.**

8，大扩张的停止与其发生同样具有重要意义

大扩张及其意义是很容易被观察的，毕竟在几个世纪里文明的疆域惊人地扩大了，这显然让任何观察都忽视不了，更别说扩张后期还形成了几个名垂千古的帝国。但是人们很难注意到的一点是，扩张的停止与扩张本身一样具有非常重大的历史意义，古典帝国获得明确的边界是封建化的一个重要推动力。为什么这么说呢？首先我们可以做一个简单的思想实验，当人类社会从以直接剥削劳动力的奴隶制社会向通过租税剥削农业剩余的封建社会过渡的时候，其本质上是（虽然不可能量化）土地在生产要素中取代劳动力到达了首要位置，无论这一过程具体是如何演化的。这个变化的发生最决定性的因素显然是生产力的提高使得封建生产方式更具效率，对于统治阶级来说能够获得更好的经济利益。但是人们不要忘了，在决定性因素以外还有其他因素存在，其中特别值得注意的一个概念就是“稀缺性”。这就好比经济学中显而易见的原理，当任何事物的数量多到一定程度，“稀缺性”低到一定程度，它的重要性都要下降，因为大家都不缺，所以不会认为它是重要的。反过来说，如果一件事物在生产过程中本身是不可或缺的，它的数量越少，就会越受到人们的重视。土地恰恰就是这样一个事物，从最简单的逻辑上就不难理解，如果土地相对于人口总是富余，那么土地的重要性就会受到抑制。在这种情况下，统治者必然会试图加强对被统治者的人身控制和依附关系，剥夺更多的权利。人口，而非土地被抬高到了最重要的位置，这对于封建秩序的形成是十分不利的，因为奴隶社会的因素被太多地保留下来了。

有一个稍微晚近的例子或许可以说明这一点，那就是从十五世纪开始西欧和东欧的“分流”，传统的解释认为，当西欧的工商业经济发展，迈向资本主义社会的时候，农奴制在中东欧却在扩大。我们应该指出，“分流”这个说法虽然有道理，但是却忽视了不同地区发展进程上本身就存在差异，东欧的封建化起步原来就比西欧要晚大约五个世纪，后来又受到了蒙古征服的冲击，当西欧摆脱农奴制的时候，东欧还在发展农奴制这件事情本身不值得奇怪。不过全欧洲的市场联系确实增强了这一点，因为西欧的工商业城市产生了进口大量粮食的需求，这当然会刺激东欧的封建领主强化对农业生产的控制，从而加强农奴制。

问题在于，这似乎并不能用来解释每一个东欧国家，特别是俄国。俄国人和波兰人在15世纪后期几乎同时获得了出海口，但是却采取了截然相反的政策。波兰人在征服格但斯克（德国人说的但泽）后继承了汉萨同盟在这里的贸易网络，把它作为波兰王国对外的贸易商港积极利用。但是莫斯科大公国征服诺夫哥罗德之后采取的措施是驱逐汉萨商人，在此后的三个世纪内，俄国对外出口的农产品数量极为有限，英国—莫斯科公司的成立也并未改变这一点。然而，俄罗斯的农奴制强化却是东欧各个国家中最严重的，农奴的法律地位明确，被视为地主的财产，几乎没有个人自由并且严格限制迁徙，在地主庄园中被强迫工作，缺少经济自主权，这已经跟奴隶制无法进行明确区分了。

为什么会产生这样的趋势，我认为东欧地广人稀的现实条件是一个重要原因，面对劳动力急缺的局面，俄国统治者希望增强对底层劳动者的控制不足为奇。不要说像俄国这样封建制度发展并不充分的国家，即使是在劳动力匮乏的新大陆，那些从西欧完整经历了封建社会的殖民国家独立的新政权，有些也在很长时间内没有废除奴隶制度，比如巴西。甚至于在独立时就已经是资产阶级民主政权（我这里用的是中国惯用的表述，希望不会使读到的人困惑）的美国，南方的奴隶制也在建国近一个世纪之后才结束。16世纪的俄国社会落后得多，封建契约关系不发达，城市发展滞后，市民阶层无力，经济封闭，至于中世纪社会所催生的一些重大的思想变革在俄国也不见踪影，那这样就确实无法指望俄国走上有别于农奴制加强的其他路线。

同样是从16世纪开始，俄国人借助来自西方的先进军事技术对东方和南方进行了长达三个多世纪的军事征服。任何观察者恐怕都要感慨这个过程进行得太容易了，少量的俄国征服者沿着西伯利亚的大河“之字形”前进，仅仅凭借原始的木质棱堡就能轻易击退十倍于自己的鞑靼土著，直到抵达太平洋。不久之后，南俄的鞑靼人也被征服，接着是高加索地区和中亚（之所以这里不考虑俄国人西边占领的波兰等国，是因为这些国家人口密度未必比俄国本土低，因此不参与讨论）。快速的领土增长使得原本就稀缺的人力显得更加不足，变化中的边疆让俄国统治者更加警惕农奴的流亡，特别是农奴反抗势力在边疆

地区对抗俄国中央。对于彼得一世和叶卡捷琳娜二世这样聪明的独裁者来说，他不可能不选择进一步压迫农奴。

俄国历史人口的变化也从侧面证明了这一点，从1700到1900年间，即使只考虑俄罗斯族以尽量排除被征服地区原本人口产生的影响，沙皇俄国仍然是全世界人口增长最快的国家（甚至可能没有之一），当然是排除掉那些规模过小的国家和由欧洲殖民地独立出的移民国家之后。如果不是20世纪俄国屡屡遭到毁灭性的内外政治灾难，这种增长应该会体现得更加显著。不过话又说回来，或许俄罗斯农奴制反常加强以及这一现象背后所隐含的俄国从封建社会向资本主义社会过渡遇到的重大挫折本身就是俄罗斯在二十世纪命途多舛的原因。无论中外，开疆拓土都被视为帝国的“盛事”，但是封建时期的历史表明，在不恰当的社会阶段吞并大量领土特别是地广人稀的待开发地很可能对社会进步造成反作用。就像人们也看到在地理大发现时代，热衷于“瓜分世界”并大量吞并领土的西班牙和葡萄牙都迅速衰落了，以商业利益为先的荷兰占据了优势。但是当资本主义制度在本国已经牢固确立的时候，大量吞并领土就不会对于宗主国造成困难，无非是日后让殖民地以各种形式独立出去罢了，本国的国际地位依旧处于世界一流水平，英国和法国就是如此。人类社会的复杂性可见一斑。

或许还有人会问：我国西藏的农奴制社会是不是也是如此呢？现在的西藏历史问题因为政治原因已经几乎无法被客观看待，争论的各方基本上都是站在各自立场上输出情绪，人们难以获知可靠的历史资料。但是西藏的农奴制确实跟俄国的情况有所区别，当我们说俄国的“地广人稀”，指的是劳动力相对于广大的可开发土地严重不足，而不是单纯指一个很大的范围内人口承载力却极低。藏区虽然面积广大，可是自然条件确实恶劣，如果高原的人口本身就只能维持较低水平，那么劳动力相对于粗放农业生产的需求就未必少了。比起西欧乃至俄罗斯农奴制时期的农奴只要逃亡成功还能够有一定活路，在西藏的自然条件下，农奴逃亡常常是死路一条，农奴只有边境地区向藏区之外逃亡有一定可行性，例如前往南方的尼泊尔和印度，毕竟那里的自然环境要强得多。因此虽然封建化在吐蕃帝国崩溃之后确实发生了，不过藏区因为自然条件的限制似乎演变出了强烈依赖宗教为纽带的，寺院为大封建主和区域统治中心的模式（从形式上看，有点像美索不达米亚早期的城邦，国家以神庙为中心组织），与俄国的情况区别比较大。

在这一节最后，我们指出在生产水平这个“主变量”之外引入稀缺性这个“副变量”来决定各生产要素的地位，意外地为观察人类早期国家的兴亡提供了非常良好的拟合模型。我们把目光投向美索不达米亚的古代文明，这里毫无疑问是现代国家观察早期国家演变的一个极佳的样本，该区域文明诞生非常早，早期国家阶段的历史非常漫长，同时这里出现了最早的文字，书写系统相当发达，目前已经出土的文献和各类考古证据也很多，至少让我们能够对于古代美索不达米亚各个时期社会的整体风貌有所把握。更关键的是，美索不达米亚的环境不像埃及那样稳定，也正是在一种动态的记录样本中，客观规律才得以凸显。

古美索不达米亚文明的各个政权无疑均处于早期国家阶段，（初级）劳动力在各生产要素中居于首要地位，因此主要的剥削方式是强迫性劳动。然而，两河流域特别是下游地区深受土地盐碱化的危害，土地盐碱化会削弱可利用土地面积，并且增大利用土地的成本。这样在一些时期就可能形成一种局面，人口数量相对于可供开垦的土地实在是太多了，因为土地的稀缺性上升，而劳动力的稀缺性下降，劳动力在诸生产要素中的统摄地位就出现动摇了。读者很容易想到有名的乌尔第三王朝，在乌尔第三王朝建立之前很多年里，苏美尔地区的土地盐碱化都在增加，因此小麦逐渐被更加耐盐碱的大麦所代替，在乌尔第三王朝鼎盛时期，单位土地的产出比较早王朝时期下降了约五成。同时在阿卡德帝国晚期，一次全球范围内的气候干旱事件，也导致两河流域北部依赖降水的农业区发生了社会危机，大量人口向南部苏美尔地区迁徙。因此我们看到在乌尔第三王朝统治时期，土地呈现出因为开垦成本上升和产出下降的紧缺状态，而聚落密度又显示了相当高的人口数量，一种人多地少的社会现实形成了。因此，我们能够明显的注意到，乌尔第三王朝呈现出一些“古典”的特征，最有代表性的就是高度复杂的官僚系统，以至于有一种行政极权主义的嫌疑。毫无疑问，在乌尔第三王朝统治时期，土地作为生产要素的地位迅速上升，因此我们看到了一种类似“租佃”的伪封建逻辑，国家在拥有公田的情况下，同时把大量的租佃田租给个人通常是官僚或者豪强收取固定比例的收成，同时还分发口粮田给官僚、军官甚至高级工匠，作为让他们不领实物工资的替代方案。这样从形式上看，被国家授予土地的人名义上是为王室服务，但是因为他们拥有土地的经营管理权和剩余价值占有权，呈现出了一种地主阶级的样貌。有名的大王舒勒吉维持它那庞大的官僚系统时也表现了一些古典君主的手段，他一方面通过标准化的度量衡和日历以及行

政软件抹平了地方豪族的自治空间，另一方面又通过恩赏与任免，将地方家族的子弟送往专门的苏美尔语学校，使他们得以担任公职。

我们也可以很明确的指出，乌尔第三王朝只是拥有古典特征，显然与一个真正的古典国家相去甚远。封建主义不可能从乌尔第三王朝的政治结构中生长出来，因为乌尔第三王朝的农业是内卷的，也就是投入了大量人力物力，但是边际收益却并不高。土地领主需要依附于一个官僚体制生存，如果土地所有权被划分为小块，整个地区就难以维持用来确保农业生产的公共工程。相比之下，封建化的真正展开是生产力发展的充分程度所引起的不可逆的革新，以小单元甚至是以家庭为单位进行土地开垦成为可能，这也是封建化早期自然经济出现的基石。封建化离不开先进工具和技术的出现，它们将确保从此以后土地超越初级劳动力在生产要素中居于首位。

人们可以轻易的看出，虽然看起来乌尔第三王朝在高度发达的官僚体制这个特征上与古典国家相似，但是前者仍然缺乏很多古典国家所具有的核心特征。就其本质而言，古典帝国是生产力发展到特殊阶段的产物，帝国能够通过其官僚制度获得极大的盈余，使这种盈余体现在丰富的城市生活，发达的商品经济，开放的文化创造和剧烈的对外扩张中。而乌尔第三王朝处于苏美尔文明的晚期阶段，其体制的建立一定程度上起源于生态环境恶化及人地矛盾尖锐的社会现实，后来也被用来对抗这些不利因素。因此，乌尔第三王朝所能利用的生产盈余是有限的，它能勉强维持自身的存在就已经很不容易了！所以我们看到乌尔第三王朝的疆域比阿卡德帝国要小很多，核心区基本退回了美索不达米亚南部的冲击平原，前者是一个内敛和高压强的国家。从有限的记载来看，乌尔第三王朝的军事活动的主要目的是巩固边境和治安维稳，即使是在舒勒吉这样有名的君主统治下也是如此。后来为了抵御阿摩利人的侵袭，乌尔第三王朝还在今天巴格达以北的地方修建了有名的阿摩利墙。当然，当秩序从内部崩塌的时候，边防设施也必然不可能起到作用。乌尔第三王朝当然有宏伟的城市，但是城市存在的经济意义是进行配给制，这种情况下就更不能指望具有独立的市民阶层和符合他们审美的文化活动了。至于乌尔第三王朝的文学就更有名，充斥着对皇室的颂歌和君主的神化，缺少古典帝国文学创作中对未知的探索和普世的理性。当然，我们也必须指出，乌尔第三王朝的文学形势不能够完全归罪于君主的妄自尊大，在这种极端的官僚体制下，像舒勒吉这样的君主神化自己确实也有降低复杂系统“校验成本”的功能。但这同样反映了乌尔第三王朝运行起复杂官僚体制的步履维艰。最后，我们指出乌尔第三王朝虽然看起来进出口货物的数量极多，却几乎没有任何实质性的“商品经济”，只是在运行一套国际背景下的“国家物流量化系统”。这个国家贸易行为的主要目的不在于产生利润，而是确保国家体制能够获得足够的无法自产的资源（比如金属和木材）。而白银虽然在乌尔第三王朝上被作为价值尺度，但是并不是实际的交换媒介，普通劳工和低级官僚领到的基本都是实物口粮。

当然，我们也不应该贬低乌尔第三王朝，它被视为“苏美尔复兴”也是有道理的，标准化的文字、度量衡和法律格式为后来的近东文明开辟了道路。这也足够体现在乌尔第三王朝统治下资源和权力的富集除了维持体系自身运转之外，也有卓越的文明产出。归根到底，乌尔第三王朝的体制可以被视为一次危机下的社会实验，并不是其统治者有预谋、有计划地出于短期的私利扼杀了整个社会的未来。乌尔第三王朝的统治模式注定不可能长久，官僚体制有自我增殖的倾向，过于精密的社会管理缺少抵御突发灾害的冗余度，在劳动密集型农业下土地盐碱化也不可避免地进一步加剧。因此，乌尔第三王朝维持一个世纪的国祚也算是比较合理了。

与乌尔第三王朝相对应的，更晚的中巴比伦时期加喜特王朝则面临着一种“地多人少”的局面，这是因为古巴比伦崩溃之后两河流域经历长期战乱、瘟疫的打击，人口大量损失。相对于残存的人口，“可分配的土地”是富余的，所以加喜特王朝的统治逻辑又回到了早期国家所通行的“人身占有”上。统治者不再追求被统治者交出多少比例的谷物，而是要求被统治者个人能在特定时间从事徭役工作。在加喜特王朝的库杜如（Kudurru）石碑里记载了许多国王将大片土地赏赐给王室成员或高级将领的事实，但是石碑想强调的核心不是土地的大小和边界，而是“免除该土地人口向国家服劳役的特权”。这些事实比较清楚地表明了加喜特王朝统治时期，劳动力是毋庸置疑的首位生产要素，这非常符合人们对一个正常早期国家的理解。实际上，加喜特王朝是公认的古代美索不达米亚官僚化程度较低，统治比较松散的政权。国王通过依靠封臣外包了对于劳动力的管辖权，这倒是有点像西周封邦建国的“授民授疆土”。我们通过对于古代美索不达米亚文明两个很有代表性政权的考察，再一次证明了我们所建立的社会学框架在人类历史时空中的普适性。

这样一来，我们就对于马克思的基于阶级分析的“历史唯物主义”进行了卓有成效的修补。统治阶级及相应阶级关系的变动取决于首位生产要素的变动，而哪个生产要素在特定历史时期能够具有统摄地位，从根本上取决于生产力的发展水平。总体来看，迄今为止（初级）劳动力，土地和资本依次作为首位生产要素。这是非常符合历史直觉的：在农业革命前的漫长时期，少量人类通过狩猎采集的方式生活在广袤无垠的土地上，劳动力当然是最重要的。在公元前后的大扩张结束之后，古典帝国的兴起将农业文明的影响扩大到大陆的大部分地区，承载农业的土地是最重要的。在工业革命之后，人类从农业文明转为工业文明，资本的重要性得以彰显。而在这三个典型状态之间是漫长的变化时期，生产力在不断进步的同时，各生产要素的重要性也受到其他副变量的干扰。而潜在副变量中最显著的就是“稀缺性”，有余的生产要素地位变得更低，而不足的生产要素地位变得更高。“稀缺性”不直接对生产力起作用，却能够在相当程度上改变生产关系。另一个影响因子，商业贸易，既不作用于最基本的生产力，也不作用于生产关系，而是直接作用于上层建筑：它能够显著增强国家官僚体制的力量。在古代表现为重要贸易路线上的国家往往较早表现出古典特征，或者在古典时代结束后仍能长期维持古典特征。而在现代则表现为一些重要资源出口国能够维持与其实际发展水平不匹配的军事力量和影响力。通过这三个层级重要性不同的影响因子，人类的历史就可以被重构的阶级学说基本解释通了。

最后我简单提一句，稀缺性关系肯定不会只出现于劳动力和土地这两个生产要素之间，土地和资本，甚至劳动力和资本一样会构成稀缺性关系。我们甚至应该指出，与那些善良天真的西方观察家看到的相反，复辟官僚国家所出现的惊人稀缺性非但不是“制度运行的失误”，而且很可能是“以维护体制自身存在为目的的必要手段”。与商业投机中国积居奇只为在短期内赚快钱不同，复辟官僚制度试图在几代人甚至更长的时间里通过人为制造稀缺性强制扭转生产关系以维护其自身统治。这种极为险恶的用心是不身在其中的人无法体会的到的。